

8.6

Image, quality, value

A Read the following comments and questions. Decide which are relevant to your company and make a few notes. Then discuss your ideas.

- 1 A *brand* is a product or company with a well-known name. If a product has a good *brand name* or a company has a strong *brand image* then it has an advantage over its competitors.
 - Are your products well-known brands?
 - What image does your company have?
 - What strategies do you have to develop your brand image?
- 2 Advertisers try to create an association between buying a product and buying a feeling or lifestyle. For example, when you choose a Land Rover car, you are buying freedom, adventure and independence.
 - Do you use advertising that is designed to sell a lifestyle or develop a brand image rather than just give information?
 - What feeling or lifestyle do customers 'buy' when they buy your products?
- 3 Some businesses compete on price, others on quality.
 - When your customers say that they are looking for *quality* in the product or service that you offer, what exactly do they mean?
 - How do you convince them of the quality of your products?
- 4 In most areas of modern business there are many similar companies selling similar, high-quality products. To survive you have to compete on customer service and added value. For example, when you go into McDonalds you don't just expect a hamburger. You expect quick service, friendly employees, a clean restaurant, a convenient location and free parking. These are as much a part of the McDonalds product as the hamburger.
 - What do your customers expect, *in addition to* your basic product?
 - What aspects of your customer service procedures give you an advantage over your competitors?

B Do you think this comment is true? Prepare a mini-presentation, giving examples from your own company.

In modern business it is not enough to sell products, you have to sell solutions. So standardized products are becoming less common. Instead, products are being tailor-made to the customer's exact requirements.

